



#AI4Elections Hackathon | Artificial Intelligence for Electoral Innovation, Integrity & Inclusion

CONCEPT DOCUMENT

Application Opens from Midnight - Thursday 8th October 2026

Application Deadline - Thursday 29th October 2026 at 11:59pm WAT

Project Period - October 2026 - February 2027

Format - National, multidisciplinary and nonpartisan

A Project of Rise Networks in collaboration with Technical Private Sector Partners and Relevant Public Agencies

1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The #AI4Elections Hackathon is a national, multidisciplinary, nonpartisan electoral innovation project created by Rise Networks to mobilise and connect Nigeria's technology ecosystem, electoral experts, academic institutions, young innovators, researchers, developers and civil society to develop usable, practical, safe and responsible artificial intelligence and emerging technologies tools, solutions, platforms and applications for electoral processes, integrity, transparency, inclusion and democratic participation in Nigeria. *This is purely a Design and Develop only Competition. Participants are expected to build working solutions.*

As artificial intelligence becomes increasingly influential in information production, digital communications, public administration and civic participation, there's a growing need for practical, evidence-based and responsible tech especially AI Solutions, that can strengthen electoral integrity, improve access to reliable information, support transparency and expand inclusion. Nigeria's electoral environment presents an opportunity to bring together technical talent and electoral expertise to develop solutions that respond to real-world challenges, while protecting fundamental rights, privacy, institutional independence and public trust.

The #AI4Elections Hackathon will provide a structured platform for participants to identify electoral challenges, collaborate across disciplines, build and demonstrate working prototypes, conduct research and develop technology-enabled approaches to electoral innovation.

The Project will be delivered through three connected pillars:

- i. *The #AI4Elections Hackathon* - the national competition and innovation showcase.
- ii. *The #AI4Elections Infrastructure Lab* - a post-hackathon incubation and validation programme.
- iii. *The #AI4Elections Community of Practice* - a sustained non-partisan national network of innovators, developers, researchers, universities, electoral experts, civic organisations and tech partners working on the responsible use of AI and technology for electoral integrity, inclusion and ethical public participation.

Rise Networks is the project initiator and owner. INEC, relevant public institutions, universities, technology companies, civil society organisations and development partners are welcome to participate in appropriate institutional, technical, research,

mentorship and sponsorship capacities. The inaugural edition of the #AI4Elections Hackathon begins on the 8th of October 2026, culminating in a national finals and prize giving ceremony in Abuja in December 2026 followed by a structured incubation and institutional engagement programme. The ultimate objective is to establish a recurring Nigerian platform for developing responsible electoral technology, strengthening national AI talent and supporting public-interest innovation beyond a single electoral cycle.

2. BACKGROUND AND RATIONALE

Artificial intelligence is transforming the way people access information, communicate, analyse data and interact with public institutions. Its applications offer opportunities for improving public services and civic participation, but also introduce risks relating to synthetic media, misinformation, privacy, cybersecurity, algorithmic bias and the manipulation of information environments. Elections are particularly sensitive to these developments because they depend on public confidence, accurate information, institutional accountability, transparent processes and the ability of citizens to participate freely. Nigeria has a growing ecosystem of technology entrepreneurs, AI researchers, university-based innovators, software developers, data scientists and civic technology organisations but the people developing technology and the people with deep knowledge of electoral processes do not always have structured opportunities to work together. The #AI4Elections Hackathon seeks to bridge this gap as it will connect electoral problem owners and subject-matter experts with technical talent, enabling teams to move from problem identification to research, prototyping, testing and potential implementation.

The Hackathon is not intended to develop partisan campaign technology, influence voter preferences or interfere with electoral administration. It is designed to support nonpartisan, public-interest innovation that respects electoral law, democratic rights and responsible AI principles. By creating a structured pipeline for talent development, prototype evaluation, research and institutional engagement, Rise Networks aims to contribute to a stronger ecosystem for responsible electoral technology in Nigeria.

3. PROJECT GOAL

Goal: To establish a national platform that mobilises Nigerian and Africa-connected talent to develop, test and promote responsible AI and technology solutions for electoral integrity, transparency, inclusion and democratic participation.

4. OBJECTIVES

This Programme seeks to:

1. Identify and support practical AI and technology solutions addressing clearly defined electoral challenges.
2. Mobilise multidisciplinary talent from universities, technology companies, research institutions, startups and civil society.
3. Strengthen technical capacity in AI engineering, data science, cybersecurity, electoral technology, responsible AI and civic innovation.
4. Encourage evidence-based research into the opportunities, risks and governance implications of AI in elections.
5. Facilitate collaboration between innovators and relevant electoral, academic, public-sector and civil society stakeholders.
6. Establish a national database and sustained community of electoral innovators, researchers, developers, mentors and institutional partners.
7. Support promising prototypes through incubation, technical validation, mentorship and potential institutional pilots, subject to relevant approvals.
8. Produce practical research, policy recommendations and an annual electoral innovation report.

5. PROJECT CORE & SUSTAINABILITY STRATEGY

The **#AI4Elections** Hackathon 2026 - 2027 is conceived not as a standalone competition, but as the foundation of a sustainable, multi-year national platform for responsible artificial intelligence, electoral innovation and democratic participation in Nigeria. Following the conclusion of the inaugural edition, Rise Networks will work with its partners to establish a structured post-hackathon pathway through which promising solutions will receive continued technical mentorship, product refinement, incubation support, infrastructure access and opportunities for responsible piloting and deployment, subject to appropriate institutional approvals. The initiative will also seek to establish an enduring #AI4Elections community of developers, researchers, university students, civic innovators and technology entrepreneurs, supported by continuous capacity-building programmes, research collaborations, knowledge-sharing activities and partnerships with technology companies, academic institutions, electoral stakeholders and development organisations. Through subsequent annual editions, strategic partner commitments, institutional collaboration, resource mobilisation and the development of an #AI4Elections research and knowledge platform, Rise Networks plans to build a sustainable national ecosystem that continuously develops locally relevant AI solutions, strengthens Nigeria's electoral technology capacity and contributes to more inclusive, transparent, accessible and accountable democratic processes. The long-term ambition is to establish #AI4Elections as a recognised African platform for responsible electoral AI innovation, with the capacity to support research, talent development, technology testing and cross-country knowledge exchange across the continent.

The Key Pillars of this Initiative

Pillar 1 | #AI4Elections Hackathon

National open call, team formation, bootcamps, innovation challenges, prototype development, judging, awards and grand finale.

Pillar 2 | #AI4Elections Innovation Lab

Post-hackathon incubation, technical testing, safety reviews, mentorship, product refinement, research development and potential institutional pilots.

Pillar 3 | #AI4Elections Community

National registry, university chapters, technical and research sessions, mentorship network, alumni engagement and continuing innovation challenges. These pillars are designed as a connected programme, and the hackathon is expected to identify talent and promising solutions; the Innovation Lab will support selected projects; and the community will sustain participation and collaboration over time.

6. #AI4ELECTIONS HACKATHON TRACKS

The inaugural edition will feature five principal challenge areas.

Track 1: AI and Electoral Information Integrity

Solutions for detecting, assessing and responding to AI-generated or manipulated electoral information, synthetic media, impersonation and misleading content. Outputs are expected to include information verification tools, provenance systems, multilingual fact-checking assistance and responsible information-analysis systems.

Track 2: Electoral Data Intelligence

Responsible AI applications for analysing authorised electoral datasets, improving data quality, processing public documents, supporting logistics analysis and identifying data anomalies for human review. Solutions must not independently declare electoral results or substitute algorithmic outputs for legally authorised electoral processes.

Track 3: Inclusive and Multilingual Electoral/Civic Technology

Accessible voter-information tools, Nigerian-language electoral and civic information, assistive interfaces for people with disabilities, digital literacy solutions and technology addressing barriers to electoral participation.

Track 4: Electoral Cybersecurity and Resilience

Defensive tools, authorised simulations, security monitoring concepts, privacy-preserving systems and resilience approaches for electoral technology. No testing of live electoral systems or unauthorised access to institutional infrastructure will be permitted.

Track 5: Election Observation and Citizen Accountability

Tools for structured observation reporting, incident documentation, civic feedback, public information access and transparency, with appropriate safeguards for observers and citizens. Final problem statements will be developed with relevant subject-matter experts and prospective institutional partners. Participation by an institution will not imply endorsement of any solution.

The Programme welcomes responsible innovation, particularly where technology can contribute to voter education, accessibility, operational efficiency, public information and greater citizen understanding of the electoral process. Participants are encouraged to develop solutions for improving voter education, simplifying electoral information, improving accessibility, helping citizens locate and understand publicly available electoral information, supporting election training, analysing publicly available election data, or modelling election logistics using simulated datasets. Where data is required, the preference should be for publicly available, anonymised, aggregated or synthetic data.

7. PARTICIPANTS AND ELIGIBILITY

The programme will be open to eligible Nigerian and Africa-connected participants, including:

- University students, recent graduates and postgraduate researchers.
- All Participants must be of Nigerian Origin and must be at least 18 years old as of the commencement date of the deadline date of this Hackathon
- Software developers, AI engineers, data scientists and cybersecurity professionals.
- Academic researchers, lecturers and independent scholars.
- Startups, technology entrepreneurs and civic-tech innovators.
- Electoral experts, election observers and civil society practitioners.
- Product designers, accessibility specialists, linguists and communication researchers.
- Public-policy, governance, legal and data protection professionals.
- Emerging innovators and young people through a supervised youth pathway.

Requirements for Academia - At least one faculty lead, a student or post-grad researcher & cover letter of approval by the appropriate HOD in an accredited Institution within Nigeria.

Requirements for Start Ups/Organizations - Valid Registration Documents include CAC Certificate, no less than 60% team membership must be resident in Nigeria and Government ID for all individual team members.

Requirements for Individuals - Valid Government ID + ID of any Organization individual is affiliated with.

Idea Only Proposals, Decks, Presentations, Research Papers, Applications submitted in any other Language apart from English, Applications submitted by Non-Nigerians, Mock Ups, Projects that have already received any form of grants, awards or recognition in other previous competitions are ineligible in this Hackathon.

Applications may be submitted by individuals or teams of no more than 4 Persons, and individual applicants will have an opportunity to participate in structured team matching. All Applications must be all submitted in English and each team member must register individually, satisfy all eligibility requirements, and be identified as part of the same team before the registration deadline. Entries submitted by teams will be judged as a single entry and an individual may participate in only one competition

entry. Membership in Teams cannot be changed after the Hackathon begins. If a team entry is selected as a winner, the award will be made to the team collectively and will count as one of the three final winning teams. Winning Teams are expected to nominate their representative who will be best suited to represent them at the Grand Finale in person, and the Rise Networks judging panel will make the final determination.

The Hackathon seeks broad participation across Nigeria's six geopolitical zones, with targeted outreach to women, persons with disabilities, vulnerable groups, underserved communities and institutions outside major technology ecosystems. Secondary school participants will be considered through an age-appropriate, supervised youth category.

8. COMPETITION DELIVERABLES

This is purely a Design + Develop only Competition. *Participants are expected to develop working solutions.* The principal competition deliverable is a working prototype or technically credible proof of concept addressing a defined electoral problem. Depending on the track, eligible outputs are expected to include:

- AI-enabled applications, tools and dashboards.
- Software prototypes, models and data-analysis pipelines.
- Research papers, policy briefs and technical methodologies.
- Accessible civic technology and multilingual information interfaces.
- Open-source components, technical documentation and evaluation frameworks.

Every competing team is required to demonstrate the problem it is addressing, explain its methodology, present evidence of functionality or technical feasibility, document limitations and outline the safeguards and conditions required for further testing. The programme will distinguish between concepts, prototypes, independently evaluated solutions and institutionally approved deployments. Winning a competition does not constitute approval for operational deployment.

9. KEY DATES

8th October 2026: Applications Open

29th October 2026: Applications Close at 11:59pm WAT

October 2026: Public launch, partner engagement, participant registration and awareness campaign, Community outreach, onboarding, technical orientation and capacity-building sessions

November 2026: Team formation, ideation, mentorship, technical development and prototype testing, solution refinement, judging, demonstrations and selection of finalists;

December 2026: Grand finale, innovation showcase, presentation of awards and announcement of winning teams; and

Jan/Feb 2027: Usability testing during election cycle, continued public relations, impact reporting, technical mentorship, solution refinement, pilot discussions and potential acceleration support for selected teams.

Institutional partners are identified accurately, and their roles and logos are included only with written permission. Given the scheduled 2027 elections, the programme prioritises research, prototype development and controlled evaluation in the pre-election period. Any operational electoral deployment must comply with the relevant legal, institutional, technical and security approvals.

Activity Start date End date Duration

Application data cleaning and eligibility checks 30 Oct 2 Nov 2 working days

Technical and programme screening of applications 2 Nov 6 Nov 5 working days

Shortlisting and notification of selected participants 9 Nov 10 Nov 2 working days

Team formation and track allocation 11 Nov 13 Nov 3 working days

Participant onboarding and hackathon kickoff 14 Nov 14 Nov 1 day

Problem validation, ideation and solution design 16 Nov 20 Nov 5 working days

Technical bootcamp and mentor matching 16 Nov 20 Nov 5 working days

Prototype development sprint 21 Nov 30 Nov 10 calendar days

Mentor check-ins and technical clinics 21 Nov 30 Nov 10 calendar days

Prototype submission and documentation 30 Nov 30 Nov 1 day

11. GRAND FINALE AND NATIONAL INNOVATION SHOWCASE

The Grand Finale & National Innovation Showcase is in Abuja in December 2026. Lagos will serve as the national convening location for the hackathon, technical demonstrations, innovation exhibition, final judging, awards and recognition of participants. A separate institutional and policy showcase in Abuja will be organised subsequently to present selected outcomes to relevant electoral institutions, public-sector stakeholders, research organisations and potential implementation partners during the National Grand Finale. The two-city approach is intended to combine a technology-focused national competition with sustained institutional engagement, without duplicating the main hackathon.

11. PRIZES AND AWARDS

The Total cash prize pool is **₦10 million** for the overall winner, alongside awards for runners-up and specialist categories.

Grand Prize - 1st Place - Overall Champion - Best overall AI-for-elections solution - ₦3,000,000

2nd Place - Runner-up - Second-highest overall score - ₦2,500,000

3rd Place - Second Runner-up - Third-highest overall score - ₦1,500,000

SPECIAL INNOVATION AWARDS

- a. Research and Policy Innovation Award** - Best misinformation detection, verification or electoral information solution - **₦750,000**
- b. Electoral and Civic Inclusion Award** - Best solution for accessibility, multilingual participation or underserved voters - **₦750,000**
- c. Responsible AI and Safety Award** - Best data-driven solution for electoral analysis or accountability - **₦750,000**
- d. Cybersecurity and Resilience Award** - Best solution addressing election-related digital security or system resilience - **₦750,000**

The four special awards are open to teams across all challenge tracks. A team that wins an overall prize could also win a special award, provided it meets the criteria as that allows exceptional teams to receive more than one award while maintaining a transparent judging framework. Any other participating teams that did not win any of the top 3 Prizes are also eligible to win any of the four special awards.

Important Details

- Prize money will be awarded to winning teams. Each team is expected to identify a designated recipient and agree on how the funds will be distributed.
- The judging rubric will include technical quality, electoral relevance, innovation, feasibility, inclusion, privacy and responsible AI.
- The ₦10 million is the prize pool only. Mentorship, cloud credits, incubation and technical resources from partners are listed separately as confirmed commitments.

In addition to cash prizes, the Hackathon may be able to provide access to:

- Laptops and development equipment.
- Cloud and AI compute credits.
- Software, API and developer-tool access.
- Technical mentorship and incubation.
- Research and product-development support.
- Opportunities for professional exposure and institutional engagement.

All prizes and in-kind benefits will be disclosed transparently, with final award values and conditions published before the competition.

12. JUDGING AND EVALUATION CRITERIA

Projects will be evaluated using published criteria:

Criterion	Weight
Technical functionality and innovation	25%
Electoral relevance and practical usefulness	20%
Cybersecurity, privacy and responsible AI	20%
Inclusion, accessibility and multilingual capability	15%
Scalability, sustainability and feasibility	15%
Demonstration and documentation	5%
Total	100%

Research and youth categories may use adapted criteria appropriate to their deliverables and Judges will be selected for technical, electoral, academic, governance and civic expertise. Conflicts of interest must be disclosed, and judges will not score teams from which they stand to benefit or which they have materially mentored. Projects presenting critical security, privacy, safety or legal concerns may be excluded from awards or further testing, regardless of their technical score.

13. POST-HACKATHON INFRASTRUCTURE DEV LAB

The #AI4Elections Infrastructure Dev Lab will support a selected cohort of approximately two to four promising teams, subject to funding and mentor capacity. The incubation period is eight to twelve weeks and will be virtual. Support may include technical mentorship, code review, product development, access to compute resources, research collaboration, responsible-AI assessments, user research and potential introductions to institutions and funders. The Lab does not guarantee funding, procurement, institutional adoption or operational deployment. Any institutional pilot will require a written agreement, defined scope, relevant approvals and appropriate safeguards. The Lab will encourage a range of sustainable pathways, including independent startups, research collaborations, open-source projects, nonprofit initiatives and institutionally supported solutions.

14. #AI4ELECTIONS COMMUNITY OF PRACTICE AND NATIONAL REGISTRY

At the end of the Hackathon, Rise Networks will set up the #AI4Elections community of practice as a permanent national network for electoral technology and responsible AI. The community of practice will maintain a consent-based registry of participants, researchers, developers, mentors, institutions and alumni and its activities will include monthly technical and research sessions, quarterly project clinics, university chapters, mentorship, newsletters, research collaborations and annual innovation challenges. The registry will capture professional interests, skills, affiliations and preferred opportunities, with clear privacy notices, appropriate access controls and mechanisms for members to update or withdraw their information. The community of practice will support sustained collaboration and provide a talent and research pipeline for future public-interest technology initiatives.

15. GOVERNANCE AND PARTNERSHIPS

Rise Networks is the Principal Project Initiator and secretariat. Its responsibilities are programme design, fundraising, partner coordination, application management, competition administration, community development, reporting and post-hackathon support. The Hackathon seeks partnerships in the following areas:

Partner Category	Contribution
Electoral institutions	Subject-matter expertise, approved challenge inputs and technical engagement.
AI Experts and Firms	AI expertise, compute access, training, mentorship and technical resources.
Universities and research centres	Talent mobilisation, research, technical mentoring and evaluation.
Civil society and electoral research organisations	Electoral problem validation, civic expertise, inclusion and accountability.
Technology companies	Sponsorship, cloud credits, equipment, software, API access and technical support.
Development partners and foundations	Programme funding, inclusion, research, incubation and capacity development.

All institutional participation will be subject to appropriate approvals. Rise Networks will retain responsibility for programme governance, while each partner will retain control of its own systems, data, policies and deployment decisions.

16. SAFEGUARDING, ETHICS AND RESPONSIBLE AI GUIDELINES

The Hackathon will operate under the following principles:

- Non - Partisanship and equal treatment of participants.
- Respect for electoral law, fundamental rights and freedom of expression.
- No partisan voter persuasion, political microtargeting or manipulation of electoral participation.
- No unauthorised access to or testing of live electoral systems.
- Use of synthetic, public or explicitly authorised datasets.
- Protection of personal information and confidential institutional data.
- Human oversight of consequential decisions and clear documentation of model limitations.
- Accessibility and inclusion in programme design and technology development.
- Transparent prize rules, intellectual property terms and conflict-of-interest management.

All teams will be required to sign a participant code of conduct and comply with the published technical and data-use rules.

17. MONITORING, EVALUATION AND LEARNING

The Hackathon will measure performance across participation, innovation, capacity development, community growth and post-event outcomes. The First-edition planning targets include:

Indicator	Target
Applications	300 to 500 individuals
Universities represented	Minimum of 15
Teams selected for the programme	25 – 40
Finalist projects	8 – 12
Incubation cohort	5 - 8 teams
Opted-in community members	300+

Additional indicators include diversity of participation, prototype functionality, completion of technical reviews, post-event team retention, mentorship engagement, research outputs and potential institutional pilots. Rise Networks will produce an inaugural outcome report documenting participation, projects, awards, lessons learned, responsible-AI assessments and recommendations for future editions. In-kind contributions such as cloud credits, laptops, equipment, venue support and professional services will be separately documented and will not be represented as cash funding.

19. SPONSORSHIP AND PARTNERSHIP OPPORTUNITIES

Rise Networks invites technology companies, financial institutions, telecommunications providers, development partners, foundations, universities and research institutions to support the inaugural edition.

Partnership opportunities include:

- Title and principal sponsorship.
- Prize pool sponsorship.
- Cloud, AI and developer infrastructure sponsorship.

- Laptops and equipment sponsorship.
- University and youth participation sponsorship.
- Research and innovation incubation sponsorship.
- Travel, accommodation and national outreach sponsorship.
- Technical mentorship, judging and institutional engagement.

20. CONCLUSION

The #AI4Elections Hackathon represents an opportunity to connect Nigeria's technology talent with the needs of electoral integrity, inclusion and democratic participation. Through the combined strengths of competition, incubation and community-building, Rise Networks will create a platform where technical talent and electoral expertise can collaborate to develop practical, responsible and evidence-based solutions for Nigeria's electoral and democratic processes. This inaugural edition will serve as the foundation for a recurring national initiative that supports AI talent development, public-interest innovation, independent research and constructive engagement with electoral stakeholders. Rise Networks welcomes partnerships with institutions and individuals committed to responsible electoral technology, electoral integrity, inclusion and democratic participation.